Central government in Delhi before he starts taking big decisions,' was the explanation I was given.

But Modi must know as a shrewd politician that he was elected as an agent of change, not continuity. That is what the idea of 'hope' was premised upon. That Modi is capable of being a change agent is doubtless. A Modi acolyte tells a delicious story of his leader taking on the Planning Commission when he was Gujarat chief minister. Modi was convinced that the Planning Commission was an impediment to faster growth. So at a meeting in Yojana Bhavan, he insisted on showing all the commission members a ten-minute video before meeting them for additional grants. The video showed in stark terms why Modi believed the Planning Commission should not exist!

A similar desire to rewrite the rules was witnessed when the Modi government decided to call off Indo-Pakistan foreign secretary-level talks after the Pakistan high commissioner met separatist Kashmiri Hurriyat leaders. The Hurriyat meetings at the Pakistan High Commission had been a familiar kebab and *kahwa* ritual; the ministry of external affairs, too, didn't seem to get agitated over it. Modi, though, has drawn a Lakshman-rekha for Indo-Pak diplomacy. As a seasoned diplomat remarked, 'You just can't have cross-border firing and sari–shawl diplomacy at the same time. Modi is not Manmohan, he is not even Vajpayee.'

It is that ability to break with convention, to challenge the Lutyens' Delhi establishment, to be adventurous in his thought and execution that will define Modi's prime ministership. He is leading India's first genuine right-of-centre majority government—Vajpayee's NDA was a loose coalition arrangement—and therefore has the mandate to effect a dramatic transformation.

Will this change alter inter-community relations as well? The 2014 election verdict has revived and emboldened the RSS and its affiliates—RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat has described India as a Hindu nation and Hindutva as its core identity. A Goa BJP minister echoed the sentiment. Minority affairs minister Najma Heptullah even went so far as to suggest there is nothing wrong in calling all Indians 'Hindu'—it is a badge of